BJP leader and Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan was insisting that "99 per cent" of the NDA's seats had been finalised. This was two days after the alliance announced its seat-sharing deal, allocating 101 seats each to the BJP and JD(U), 29 to Chirag Paswan's LJP (Ram Vilas), and six each to Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha or HAM(S) and Upendra Kushwaha's Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM).

THE SAME BOGEYMAN

Yet things were not that simple. The NDA's planned joint press conference on October 13 was abruptly postponed. Nitish is believed to have voiced strong reservations over the concessions granted to Chirag's LJP. Sources in the JD(U) say Paswan Jr is up to his old tricks, eyeing several of their seats. His healthy haul of 29 seats, after all, has to come from somewhere—the formula worked out apparently entailed some friendly scavenging on old JD(U) bases, where it has sitting MLAs. That prompted Nitish to put his foot down, eliciting a round of damage control by the BJP.

Takeaways

- **For the first time, JD(U) takes 101 seats, its lowest and on par with the BJP**
- **Chirag Paswan's LJP gets 29 seats; Nitish angry about its incursions into JD(U) base**
- **RJD-Congress talks are equally fraught. No clarity on Tejashwi as CM, Rahul's yatra momentum at stake for cadre**

This is, incidentally, the first time the JD(U) has had to climb down before an assembly election, agreeing to contest on an equal footing with the BJP. Given Chirag's open alignment with the latter—and the fact that both Manjhi and Kushwaha depend more on the saffron party than the JD(U)—the seat distribution, in effect, reads thus: JD(U) 101 versus BJP + allies 142. An upbeat saffron party announced 71 candidates by October 14, but there have been ugly scenes at their Patna party office too.

Across the aisle, the Mahagathbandhan, comprising the Rashtriya Janata Dal, Congress, Left parties and smaller regional outfits, is also in a muddle. The RJD, led by Tejashwi Yadav, continues to dominate the bloc, but the Congress is still hesitant to formally declare him as a clear CM candidate for the alliance. That partly stems from the legal troubles of father Lalu Prasad and the recent framing of charges in the IRCTC case. But it once again unsettled the front.

Insiders say ticket distribution meetings have been tense, even acrimonious. The RJD's effort to project itself as a vehicle for Bihar's restless youth—built largely around Tejashwi's promise of government jobs—risks being undercut by the indecision. The Congress seems willing to contest less seats than the 70 last time, but wants constituencies where they stand a chance, not merely the ones the RJD deigns to offer. The delay in candidate confirmations has everyone on edge (nominations close on October 17), which is not helping the Congress cadre who, after years of decline, had appeared energised by Rahul Gandhi's Jan Adhikar Yatra.

New-kid-on-the-block Prashant Kishor's Jan Suraaj Party had already announced 165 candidates by the 14th (PK himself may not contest, focusing on campaigning for the party). His message is exact: a rejection of both the "failed rulers" and the "opportunistic Opposition". The JSP has set up a grassroots presence in parts of Bihar, particularly among first-time voters and sections disillusioned with both major alliances. But, as of now, his campaign threatens to fragment the anti-incumbency vote rather than consolidate it.

The image of Mandal squatting outside his own CM's gate endures as the perfect metaphor for Bihar's current political climate: alliances at war with themselves, waiting till the last moment for things to fall in place. ■

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

FREED, K

Azam's release from prison

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

POWER DOES NOT VANISH in politics. It only waits for the right moment to reclaim itself. That moment might have arrived for Azam Khan. In his case, that first axiom applies uniquely: it was not on account of any plunge in his popular stock that he went into oblivion. He was put there by the law, maximally interpreted.

Now, after spending nearly two years in jail on multiple charges, Azam Khan is free, so is his instinct to play for centrality as the main Muslim face of the Samajwadi Party (SP). At least that's the script till now. Multiple futures and options seem open for him. With no shortage of suitors, he has the chips to extract his bargains—in the SP or outside.

A founding member of the SP and a loyal Mulayam Singh Yadav lieutenant, the ten-time MLA from Rampur had a voice that carried beyond his constituency. Over the years, he was a state cabinet staple and his support base encompassed the 'PDA' rainbow in western UP.

That segues well into SP supremo Akhilesh Yadav's strategic positioning. Trouble is, Khan's equations with Akhilesh have always been less chummy than those with his father. That lingered through his prison years: Khan apparently felt the SP leadership did little to back him in his